

1962

JANUARY 12

Operation Ranch Hand begins. American aircraft spray large areas of rural South Vietnam with herbicides, chiefly Agent Orange, to destroy vegetation and deprive guerrillas of cover and food.

FEBRUARY 8

The United States sets up the Military Assistance Command, Vietnam (MACV) to support South Vietnam against the Viet Cong. General Paul Harkins is appointed MACV commander.

MARCH 19

The South Vietnamese government launches its Strategic Hamlets Program, intended to defeat the rural insurgency by protecting peasants from communist influence.



The Strategic Hamlets program, implemented in 1962

DECEMBER 31

By the year's end, the number of US military personnel in Vietnam is 11,300. The American death toll for the year is 53.